

JACKSON COUNTY

Friends shocked by word of South MS teen's death. 'He could spark up a room.'

By **Anita Lee**

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Sun Herald Breaking News

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By Miranda Daniel

Key Takeaways

AI-generated summary reviewed by our newsroom.

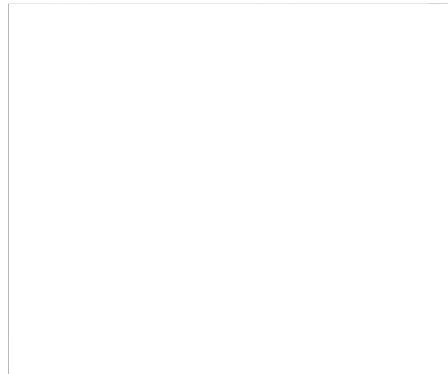
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Friends streamed to the waterside at the Lake Mars Boat Launch, where they consoled the family of 18-year-old Nolan Xavier Wells of Ocean Springs [after a body](#)

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matching his description was found off the western tip of Horn Island, where he was last seen on a crowded beach on July Fourth.

Wells' mother and father, Christine and Elmore Wonsley, were too distraught to speak as they spent a second morning by the waterside awaiting word from rescuers who were bringing a body to shore. Those close to them offered comfort and hugs.



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AD

Nolan Wells' closest friends from childhood remembered the kind, easy-going young man who was supposed to head back to Southwest Mississippi Community College in Summit on Monday to practice for the [upcoming football season](#). They couldn't believe he was gone.



Wells had a tight circle of friends raised with him in Ocean Springs. He was a calming influence. If an argument broke out when the kids were younger, Wells was the one likely to break it up. He was friendly to everyone and usually wore a smile, his friends said.

“He could spark up a whole room,” said one of his friends, who called Wells “a great role model.”

Wells also knew how to swim. His friends said they had even taken lessons at the YMCA in Ocean Springs.



Trace Carter, left, and Jayvon Williams, right, were longtime friends of Nolan Xavier Wells, whose body searchers believe they recovered Monday morning off the western tip of Horn Island. The young men were among family and friends who comforted one another at the Lake Mars Boat Launch, where emergency responders staged search boats. Williams, who was also on Horn Island for the Fourth but on a different boat from Wells, visited with Wells shortly before he went missing. Anita Lee calee@sunherald.com

Awaiting word

Several of the young men at the dock played ball with Wells in Ocean Springs. Football, basketball, baseball — they played it all. After graduation, Wells played wide receiver for the Southwest Community College Bears.

Doris Hands was a grandmother to the childhood friends. Like the others, Wells called her “Mama D.” She said that he always gave her a hug and minded his manners.

“He was a good person,” Hands said, “loved sports, kind-hearted.”

He would have celebrated his 19th birthday in August.

“It really, really hurts,” said Hands, who has awaited word since Saturday evening, when Wells failed to return from the island. “After the first day and no contact, I expected this.”

Wells headed to Horn Island on Saturday with friends. His best friend, 17-year-old Jayvon Williams, said he was supposed to be on the same boat, but it filled up. Williams rode out on a different boat, but he saw Wells on the island. He believes he saw Wells for the last time after 4 p.m. Saturday.



A boat prepares to take off Monday at Lake Mars Boat Launch. Jackson Ranger jranger@sunherald.com

Wells visited with a girl, Williams said, but also chatted with other friends in the

“As soon as we got out there,” Williams said, “he told me that he loved me.” Wells always had Williams’ back. If somebody talked bad about Williams, Wells stuck up for his friend.

Both young men left their phones on the boat that Wells rode out on. Williams later retrieved his phone, while Wells’ mother found her son’s phone through location services, Hands said.

Wells was last seen near the western tip of Horn Island, where the current is strong.

Trace Carter talked to Wells before the island trip. Carter told Wells: “Just hit me up when you get back. Just be careful, bro. Watch out for yourself.”

Wells responded, “I got you. I’ll hit you up later.”



Nolan Wells did not return home Saturday, July 4, 2026, after spending the day on Horn Island. *Provided*

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Anita, a Mississippi native, graduated with a journalism degree from the University of Southern Mississippi and previously worked at the Jackson Daily News and Virginian-Pilot, joining the Sun Herald in 1987. She specializes in in-depth coverage of government, public corruption, transparency and courts. She has won state, regional and national journalism awards, most notably contributing to Hurricane Katrina coverage awarded the 2006 Pulitzer Prize in Public Service.
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